some fine hospitality at the Glenburn Penthouse, one of the most coveted upscale boutique addresses in town, I set off for Outram Ghat in the morning. We checked in and freshened up with the wet towels and welcome coolers arranged by the nimble staff, before climbing up on the partially shaded sundeck for a round of introductions.

As she journeyed upstream, the *Rajmahal* sailed under one metal bridge after another, and the group's glee reached an all-time high when the colossal Howrah Bridge—the enduring Calcutta icon—materialised in the offing. In a few minutes, the ship slid under it as both sets of travellers—those passing on the bridge and those planted on the boat's terrace, gazed at the other in primordial wonder.

Five hours or so passed, and we hopped off the boat to explore Barrackpore—India's first cantonment town. Before the British discovered and made Shimla their summer capital in 1864, Barrackpore was their favourite hot weather retreat. We disembarked near Mangal Pandey Park (locally known as Latbagan) and set off for a tour of the cantonment, sauntering past reminders of British rule such as the sprawling Flagstaff House, a pre-telegraph-era semaphore tower that looked like a riverside lighthouse, and the Temple of Fame, a handsome cenotaph in the Roman style installed by Lord Minto to honour British soldiers who died in the 1810 conquest of Java. I later learned that the Barrackpore Park close to the bank was where Lady Canning, India's first vicereine and a prolific painter, was buried.

A MARRIAGE OF FRANCE AND BENGAL

Much like Palashi, the carefree and youthful Chandannagar has redefined history in its own way. The following morning, we left our ship moored in the middle of the Hooghly, boarded the ferry and stepped into the former French colony. Also called Chandernagore/ Chandernagor (though this is frowned upon, I learned), this eclectically arranged town with vibrant houses and French blinds remained under the European power's control until the early 1950s. Yet today, it seems happy to interpret in its own way the vestiges of French imperialism that continue to attract travellers. From The Strand, the loftily named riverside promenade where plaques stand dedicated to Bengali gentlemen with names like Dourga Chorone Roquitte, and the Dupleix House, which now functions as a museum, to the various French-established educational institutions, the town betrayed not one fleck of self-doubt.

As the Kanailal Dutta School in the main thoroughfare celebrated a jubilee year, the whole town seemed occupied with festivity, and soon a school procession rolled past the Sacré





